PROJECT DETAILS

PROJECT NAME
E-commerce Returns Management
CREATOR
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DOCUMENT NO.	DATE	VERSION NO.
1	October 2026	1.0

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY SNAPSHOT

This Business Requirements Document (BRD) outlines the business objectives, scope, stakeholder needs, and success criteria for developing an E-commerce Returns Feature for an online shopping application. The project aims to simplify product returns, improve customer satisfaction, and reduce fraudulent return requests by enabling customers to return eligible products within 15 calendar days of delivery.

The proposed feature will support return eligibility validation, return reason selection, automated approval for eligible requests, courier pickup coordination, return status tracking, and refund processing within 48 hours after quality control (QC) approval. It will also support fraud prevention and provide Finance with visibility into return-related costs.

Project success will be measured against proposed targets, including return initiation in under two minutes, a fraudulent return rate below 2%, and customer satisfaction of at least 85%. The project deliverables include a separate Functional Requirements Document (FRD), two wireframes, and an Excel requirements traceability matrix to support solution design, testing, and delivery planning. Live development and production deployment are outside the project scope.

2. **PROJECT DESCRIPTION**

The project aims to develop an E-commerce Returns Feature that enables customers to initiate and track product returns through an online shopping application. The proposed solution will allow customers to request returns for eligible purchases within 15 days of delivery, select a return reason, and monitor the progress of their requests.

Currently, the assumed returns process relies on customers contacting support or navigating a process that may lack clear eligibility checks, automated approvals, and transparent status updates. This can lead to delays, increased support workload, inconsistent return handling, and difficulties coordinating return pickups, quality checks, and refunds.

The key challenges include preventing fraudulent return requests, enforcing product-specific return policies, reducing the time required to initiate a return, and improving coordination between customer support, finance, and warehouse operations. Customers may also experience uncertainty about return progress and refund timelines.

The proposed feature will introduce automated return eligibility validation, including restrictions on non-returnable categories such as innerwear, automated approval for eligible size-related returns, courier pickup request creation, refund processing within 48 hours after quality control approval, and fraud-based return restrictions. A return status tracking screen will provide customers with greater visibility, while a return cost dashboard will support financial monitoring.

The project is intended to improve customer satisfaction, strengthen fraud prevention, and increase operational efficiency. Proposed success measures include reducing return initiation time to under two minutes, maintaining the fraudulent return rate below 2%, and monitoring customer satisfaction through the Customer Satisfaction Score (CSAT).

3. **PROJECT SCOPE**

IN-SCOPE ITEMS	OUT-OF-SCOPE ITEMS
Item 1: Return Initiation and Eligibility Validation: Enable customers to initiate returns within 15 days of delivery, with product category validation and return reason selection.	**Item 1:** Unrelated E-commerce Features: Development or modification of product catalogues, shopping carts, order placement, and other features unrelated to returns.
Item 2: Return Processing and Fraud Prevention: Support automated approval for eligible size-related returns, block requests from users flagged for fraud, and facilitate courier pickup and refunds within 48 hours after QC approval.	**Item 2:** Live Deployment and External System Implementation: Production deployment, actual courier API integration, live fraud detection implementation, and real financial or warehouse system integration.
Item 3: Return Tracking and Financial Reporting: Provide customers with return status tracking and enable Finance to monitor return-related costs through a dashboard.	**Item 3:** Advanced Analytics and Predictive Modelling: Development of AI-based fraud prediction models, predictive return analytics, and customer behaviour forecasting beyond the defined return management requirements.

4. **FUNCTIONAL REQUIREMENTS**

FR-01: User shall initiate return within 15 days from delivery date
FR-02: System shall validate return eligibility based on category (innerwear not returnable)
FR-03: User shall select reason from dropdown (Size, Quality, Wrong Item, Not as described)
FR-04: System shall auto-approve if reason=Size and within 15 days
FR-05: System shall create pickup request via courier API
FR-06: System shall refund within 48h after QC pass
FR-07: Finance shall view return cost dashboard
FR-08: System shall block return if tagged fraud user

5. **NON-FUNCTIONAL REQUIREMENTS**

ID	REQUIREMENT
NFR-01	Performance: Return API <2 sec
NFR-02	Security: OTP for refund
NFR-03	Usability: 2-click return
NFR-04	Scalability: 1000 returns/day

6. STAKEHOLDERS AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Customer	Initiate eligible returns, select return reasons, and track return status.
Support Lead	Handle customer return queries, resolve issues, and manage exceptions.
Finance Representative	Monitor return-related costs and oversee refund processing.
Warehouse Manager	Coordinate returned-item receipt, quality inspections, and QC status updates.

7. BUSINESS REQUIREMENTS AND SUCCESS METRICS

ID	Business Requirement
BR-01	Customers shall be able to initiate returns for eligible products within 15 calendar days of delivery.
BR-02	The returns process shall enforce product eligibility rules and prevent return requests from users flagged for fraudulent activity.
BR-03	The system shall support return approval, courier pickup coordination, quality inspection, and refund processing.
BR-04	Customers shall be able to track return status, and Finance shall be able to monitor return-related costs.

8. **Success Metrics**

These targets are proposed project objectives and will require measurement against agreed definitions and baseline data.

Metric	Target
Return initiation time	Less than 2 minutes per eligible return request.
Fraudulent return rate	Below 2% of total return requests.
Customer Satisfaction Score (CSAT)	Proposed target of at least 85% satisfaction.
Refund processing time	Within 48 hours after successful quality control (QC) approval.

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9. **ASSUMPTIONS AND CONSTRAINTS**

Assumptions

- Accurate order and delivery-date information is available to validate the 15-day return window.
- Product categories and return eligibility rules are maintained and accessible to the system.
- Users flagged for suspected fraud can be identified through an existing process or data source.
- Courier and refund systems can support the required integrations in a future implementation.
- The Support Lead, Finance representative, and Warehouse Manager will provide the necessary business rules and validate requirements relevant to their responsibilities.

Constraints

- Returns are permitted only within 15 calendar days of delivery, subject to eligibility rules.
- Innerwear is excluded from returns under the proposed business policy.
- Refund processing must occur within 48 hours after QC approval.
- The project is limited to business and functional requirements documentation, wireframes, and requirements traceability; live development and production deployment are excluded.
- Performance and scalability requirements must be validated against agreed testing conditions.

10. RISKS AND MITIGATION

ID	Risk	Proposed Mitigation
R-01	Incorrect delivery dates or eligibility rules may result in invalid return approvals or rejections.	Validate delivery data and test return-window and product-category rules using defined test cases.
R-02	Incorrect fraud flags may block legitimate customer returns.	Define an exception-review and escalation process for disputed fraud flags.
R-03	Courier API failures may prevent pickup requests from being created.	Specify error handling, retry behaviour, and support escalation for failed requests.
R-04	Delayed warehouse quality inspections may delay refunds.	Track QC status, define processing targets, and establish escalation procedures for overdue inspections.
R-05	Unauthorized refund activity may create financial losses.	Require OTP verification before refund authorization and define appropriate access controls.
R-06	Unclear or incomplete requirements may cause development rework and delivery delays.	Review requirements with stakeholders, document acceptance criteria, and maintain a requirements traceability matrix.